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Lessons from Audre Lorde on Freedom, Equality, and the Politics of Difference

Current systems of government stand to benefit from a lens that incorporates *the politics of difference*, a philosophy perpetuated by Audre Lorde, a visionary thinker and poet. Lorde's approach critiques traditional Western philosophical frameworks for their promotion of homogeneity, advocating instead for a celebration of uniqueness as an essential component of societal strength. Her writings assert that true freedom is the individual expression of emotion, where feelings are a bridge toward mutual understanding and empowerment. She also explores relational equality, the idea that true fairness involves recognizing and valuing differences within the framework of equal respect and rights. Lorde posits that a just society can only be achieved when the collective does not attempt to erase difference under the guise of convenience found in uniformity. Lorde's politics of difference necessitates practical reform in current systems of governance because it advocates for a model in which individual freedom is achieved through emotional authenticity, and relational equality is cultivated through the acknowledgment of differences, creating a foundation for a more just and equitable society.

Traditional Western philosophical frameworks are built on outdated patriarchal and racially motivated constructs of freedom and must be revised. As philosopher Charles Mills explains, "the grand ethical theories propounded in the development of Western moral and political thought are of restricted scope, explicitly or implicitly intended by their proponents to be restricted to persons, whites."¹ This exclusivity assumes consent to the social contract and reveals a critical oversight in applicability and fairness. Even freedom, namely the ability to do

¹ Mills, Charles W. *The Racial Contract*. Cornell University Press, 2022, p. 17.

as one wills,² has “been generated from the experience of slavery, that the slave establishes the norm for humans.”³ Conventional understandings of freedom are paradoxically derived. This historical context renders any automatic acceptance of such political and social contract theories as naive and dangerous. The current social and political systems in America are still built on these harmful traditional frameworks and continue to exclude minorities from the social contract, especially noticeable in the lack of prison reform, racist police killings, economic disparities, health violations, and education policies.⁴ As Lorde reminds us, “the tools of a racist patriarchy are used to examine the fruits of that same patriarchy...”⁵ further requiring a reevaluation of social contract theories and prompting a need to dismantle the oppressive government systems. Relying on the very instruments that uphold these structures perpetuates inequity and makes these theories of justice an ouroboros.⁶

Lorde challenges traditional Western philosophical views by redefining freedom as an expression of feeling. Lorde writes: “The white fathers told us: I think, therefore I am. The black mother within each of us—the poet—whispers in our dreams: I feel, therefore I can be free.”⁷ Lorde critiques the Eurocentric, patriarchal valuation of Cartesian rationalism, exemplified by the famous philosophical statement, “I think, therefore I am.”⁸ She argues genuine freedom derives from emotional authenticity rather than mere rational thought. This distinction is also

² Dicker, Georges, 'Freedom and the determination of the will', *Locke on Knowledge and Reality: A Commentary on An Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (2019; online edn, Oxford Academic, 18 July 2019), <https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780190662196.003.0010>, accessed 4 May 2024.

³ Mills, p. 58.

⁴ Porter, Eduardo. “America’s Social Contract Is Still Built on Racial Hostility.” *Foreign Policy*, Graham Holdings Company, 8 June 2020, [foreignpolicy.com/2020/06/08/american-racism-welfare-state-george-floyd-protests/](https://www.foreignpolicy.com/2020/06/08/american-racism-welfare-state-george-floyd-protests/).

⁵ Lorde, Audre. “The Master’s Tools Will Never Dismantle the Master’s House.” *The Selected Works of Audre Lorde*, edited by Roxanne Gay, Norton & Company, 2020, pp. 40.

⁶ Britannica, The Editors of Encyclopædia. “Ouroboros”. *Encyclopedia Britannica*, 19 Apr. 2024, <https://www.britannica.com/topic/Ouroboros>. Accessed 4 May 2024.

⁷ Lorde, Audre. “Poetry is Not a Luxury.” *The Selected Works of Audre Lorde*, edited by Roxanne Gay, Norton & Company, 2020, pp. 5.

⁸ Duignan, Brian. “Cogito, Ergo Sum.” *Encyclopædia Britannica*, Encyclopædia Britannica, inc., 4 Apr. 2024, www.britannica.com/topic/cogito-ergo-sum.

deeply entwined with race and gender, challenging the prevailing norms of who defines knowledge and truth. Lorde elevates the emotional consciousness associated with the “black mother” as a universal force that defies the status quo. Her use of “the poet” symbolizes the antithesis of rigid, traditional structures, and instead advocates for a personal and collective freedom that is achieved through the authentic experience of one’s feelings. The road to liberation is then accessible internally and reflective of a shared, yet diverse, human experience.

To Lorde, emotions are not just personal, but also are deeply political, capable of challenging oppressive structures and fostering genuine connectivity. Understanding feelings as a liberating force inspires her perspective that emotions, particularly anger, are a powerful catalyst for change. Lorde writes that “anger between peers births change, not destruction, and the discomfort and sense of loss it often causes is not fatal, but a sign of growth,”⁹ challenging the norm that anger is harmful. Embracing emotions, especially those considered detrimental, enables the individual to break free from the burden of societal expectations. Lorde suggests that feelings like anger are not symptoms of a fractured society, but instead are essential components of an evolving community. Through the expression and confrontation of diverse emotional experiences, society must navigate disagreements and conflicts not as endpoints, but as the beginning of fruitful dialogue.

Lorde further focuses on the interconnectedness of the personal and the political in emotion and civic engagement. Her assertion that “[i]n a world of possibility for all, our personal visions help lay the groundwork for political action,”¹⁰ highlights the crucial role individual perspectives play in shaping societal reform. Personal experience is fundamental to challenging existing power structures and crafting policies that address systemic injustices. Acknowledging

⁹ Lorde, “The Uses of Anger: Women Responding to Racism” (1981), in *Sister Outsider*, 131.

¹⁰ Lorde, “The Master’s Tools,” pp 42.

individual perspective better ensures that political strategies are genuinely representative. This approach directly contributes to dismantling entrenched racial and gender inequality.

Moreover, Lorde emphasizes that the freedom to be one's own person is valuable to the greater whole. She explains: "We are a people at war, and that war must be fought by separate individuals coming together to move against our common enemy."¹¹ Lorde's vision implies that the synthesis of individual strengths makes the collective more effective than the sum of its parts. The metaphor of war speaks to the urgency and intensity with which societal battles against injustice, inequality, and oppression must be waged. These are active and cooperative endeavors, not passive or isolated struggles. While individuals may experience the "war" differently based on their position in society, the ultimate success in such a struggle relies on the ability to bridge differences and work cohesively towards one common objective. Unity, fostered through mutual respect and shared purpose, exemplifies how collective action rooted in individual contribution and shared acknowledgment is a powerful strategy for societal reform.

Understanding that Lorde's poetic ideology of freedom is driven by emotion and individuality, it is imperative to consider the other fundamental principle in which Western political philosophy is built; equality. As Mills explains, the foundation of contractarian literature is "the freedom and equality of all men in the state of nature."¹² Yet, there is a "color-coded morality" in traditional social contracts, where natural equality is exclusively afforded to white men.¹³ This exclusionary practice, rooted in a biased moral hierarchy, systematically denies people of color their rightful place in the social order due to a skewed interpretation of natural law duties. The conventional view of equality is "perpetuating the myth of sameness,"¹⁴ which

¹¹ Lorde, "Survival," April 1976, Audre Lorde Papers, Box 18, Folder 2.1.115, Spelman College Archives.

¹² Mills, p. 16.

¹³ Id.

¹⁴ Lorde, Audre. "Difference and Survival." *The Selected Works of Audre Lorde*, edited by Roxanne Gay, Norton & Company, 2020, pp. 174.

fails to acknowledge the rich diversity inherent in humanity. By insisting on sameness, equality as understood in classical theory not only negates the varied experiences shaped by “differences of race, sex, class, gender, and age,”¹⁵ but also creates “distortions curated around human differences, all serving the purpose of further separation.”¹⁶ This flawed perspective on equality effectively maintains systemic barriers and undermines the potential for genuine inclusivity and fairness in societal structures. Thus, reevaluating the foundational principle of equality in light of Mill’s and Lorde’s critiques it is essential for societal structure to foster a more balanced society that truly respects the identities of all its members.

Lorde makes clear that the prescribed, oversimplified view of equality as homogeneity has conditioned individuals to perceive differences negatively. American society is conditioned “to see human differences in simplistic opposition to each other: dominant/subordinate, good/bad, up/down, superior/inferior.”¹⁷ This black-and-white rhetoric polarizes human characteristics. It also dangerously ignores the nuances of equality. It implies that human differences create a superior and inferior, which when applied to political systems, forms the current unequal and divisive American society. This traditional way of thinking breeds governance and social policies that do not address the real needs and conditions of all citizens, and instead fosters a system that privileges conformity and marginalizes those who do not categorically fit normative standards.

Lorde calls for a relational ideology that moves away from sameness and toward a system that honors each person’s unique circumstance and struggles. She claims: “It is not [the] differences between us that are separating us. It is rather our refusal to recognize those differences, and to examine the distortions which result from our misnaming them and their

¹⁵ Lorde, *Difference and Survival*, 176.

¹⁶ Lorde, *Difference and Survival*, 175.

¹⁷ Lorde, “Age, Race, Class, and Sex: Women Redefining Difference,” in *Sister Outsider*, 114.

effects upon human behavior and expectation.”¹⁸ Lorde articulates that the real divisiveness stems from the denial of inherent differences. This ignorance perpetuates division under a veil of uniformity.

Lorde continues by arguing that ignoring and minimizing the differences in individual experiences of marginalized groups perpetuates oppression. She writes of her experience with a non-Black person of color, recounting “...rendering her invisible by assuming that her struggles with racism are identical with my own...”¹⁹ By recognizing there are nuances in experience, Lorde advocates for an approach to equality that moves beyond oppositional frameworks where individuals are categorized in polarity, the oppressor and the oppressed.

This all too often simplistic narrative of equality seeks to conform experience without addressing the layers of individual differences. Lorde points toward a deeper process of consciousness-raising, which has enabled marginalized groups to name and articulate specific forms of oppression. For example, the concept of *misogynoir*, which describes the specific hatred directed at Black women, captures the unique experience of racism and sexism this group faces, distinct from the experiences of white women and Black men.²⁰ A consciousness-raising dogma provides the language and framework necessary for individuals within these groups to voice their intimate happenings. By advocating for the acknowledgment of these specific backgrounds, Lorde is promoting a model of relational equality. It cannot be attained through standardization. Instead, true equality is achieved through the appreciation and accommodation of the diverse spectrum of human experience.

¹⁸ Lorde, “Age, Race, Class, and Sex,” 115.

¹⁹ Lorde, “Uses of Anger,” 127–28.

²⁰ Toole, Briana. “From Standpoint Epistemology to Epistemic Oppression.” *Hypatia*, vol. 34, no. 4, 2019, pp. 598–618, <https://doi.org/10.1111/hypa.12496>. (CMC Prof!!)

Discontent and polarization is prevalent in the American democratic system and it is ripe to consider Lorde's roadmap towards fostering a society that thrives on relational equality. It is time for the government to consider every voice with equal footing. Lorde's warning that "Our future survival is predicated upon our ability to relate within equality,"²¹ underscores the necessity of constructing a system that respects the inherent worth of every individual. Lorde's wisdom, "Only then does the necessity for interdependency become unthreatening,"²² encapsulates the transformative potential of embracing relational equality. Recognizing interdependency can alleviate fears of "the Other"²³ and leads to a more cohesive society. Relational equality thus involves creating relationships and societal structures that acknowledge and adapt to the varied needs and challenges of different people, ensuring that not one experience is marginalized, misunderstood, or ignored.

To achieve this, Lorde emphasizes the importance of balancing the recognition of both similarities and differences within interpersonal and communal relationships. She advises: "I do not have to be you to recognize that our wars are the same...we must allow each other our differences at the same time as we recognize our sameness."²⁴ Recognizing that individuals do not need to have identical experiences to empathize and stand in solidarity with others is crucial for overcoming the isolation that often accompanies singular-identity politics. It opens the door for more inclusive and effective alliances across diverse communities.

Lorde's insistence on the importance of identity within the political discourse challenges systemic inequalities. However, critics argue that an intense focus on identity politics can inadvertently overshadow broader socio-economic issues. Described by political scientist Mark

²¹ Lorde, "Age, Race, Class, and Sex," 122.

²² Lorde, "The Master's Tools," pp 41.

²³ Turner, Jack. "25 Audre Lorde's Politics of Difference". *African American Political Thought: A Collected History*, edited by Melvin L. Rogers and Jack Turner, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2021, pp. 563-592. <https://doi.org/10.7208/9780226726076-026>

²⁴ Lorde, "Learning from the 60s," 142.

Lilla as “a pseudo-politics of self-regard,” and “exclusionary self-definition,” a focus on identity has distracted from pervasive inequalities that cut across various identity groups, undermining civic discourse.²⁵ He believes that identity politics flops in practice, writing that it “never wins elections—but can lose them.”²⁶ The goal is “to have a message that appeals to as many people as possible and pulls them together,” but to Lilla, identity politics does the opposite.²⁷ He suggests that political success lies in crafting messages that appeal broadly and unify, whereas identity politics can fragment and isolate. While Lorde’s approach enriches political dialogue by validating personal and group identities, the challenge remains to balance these specificities with universal appeals that mobilize collective action.

Political economist and scholar Francis Fukuyama articulates a more nuanced position to integrate these personal dimensions into larger narratives that resonate across different segments of society. He contends that while the focus on narrow group identities can indeed challenge democratic deliberation and consensus, the remedy is not to discard the notion of identity but to reframe it within a broader context.²⁸ Instead, the United States and other democracies “need to promote what political scientists call ‘creedal national identities,’ which are built not around shared personal characteristics, lived experiences, historical ties, or religious convictions but rather around core values and beliefs.”²⁹ Fukuyama’s approach resonates with Lorde’s advocacy for foundational ideals like freedom and equality, suggesting a model where diverse identities are integrated under a unified national identity that celebrates common values. This perspective

²⁵ Mark Lilla, *The Once and Future Liberal: After Identity Politics* (New York: HarperCollins, 2017), pp. 9–10.

²⁶ Mark Lilla, “The End of Identity Liberalism,” *New York Times*, November 20, 2016, “Sunday Review” sec.

²⁷ Lilla, *The Once and Future Liberal*, p. 12.

²⁸ Francis Fukuyama, “Against Identity Politics: The New Tribalism and the Crisis of Democracy,” *Foreign Affairs* 97, no. 5 (September/October 2018), pp. 90–114, at pp. 104–5.

²⁹ *Id.*, pp. 106, 108.

offers a pathway to balance the recognition of unique identities with the necessity of maintaining a cohesive and operational democratic system.

It is crucial to consider how, through Lorde's lens, society can achieve governance that aligns with principles of individual emotional freedom and relational equality. Even in ancient philosophy, a government is supposed to provide for its people—all of its people.³⁰ A functioning society requires accounting for every individual and their distinct set of needs. The United States ought to establish a system where each person's unique experiences are invaluable to governmental practices. This will enable the country to address challenges not with a one-size-fits-all cover up, but instead with a tailor-made solution. In collective governance, every decision-making process must intentionally elevate the voices of those who have been systematically marginalized. This means structuring the democratic process to more actively encourage participation from everyone, especially those who have been lacking information, access, or the safety to speak freely.

In practice, a politics of difference approach requires ongoing dialogue, education, and conscious effort to dismantle systemic barriers that perpetuate inequality and division. In tackling governmental issues like community development, education, health and safety, and resource distribution, Lorde's vision urges policymakers to consider the impacts of their decisions on all races and genders. Politics must not be bound by "linear power,"³¹ and "institutional dehumanization."³² Rather, each member of society must be encouraged to address the inherent biases they experience and work to reform any system that perpetuates injustice. Lorde's outlook also involves advocating for policies and cultural norms that embrace multiplicity and ensures

³⁰ Korab-Karpowicz, W. J. "Plato: Political Philosophy." *Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy and its authors, iep.utm.edu/platopol/#:~:text=For%20Plato%2C%20as%20for%20Solon,Republic%20by%20the%20philosopher%20Drulers. Accessed 4 May 2024.

³¹ Lorde, "Poetry is Not a Luxury," pp. 6.

³² Id.

that all individuals have equal access to opportunity and resources. Valuing diversity is more than just a noble sentiment: it is essential to successful governance.

Lorde's reflections on the urgency of action despite the pervasive impact of fear provides a compelling call to confront the silences that stifle progress. She asserts that "experience has taught us that action in the now is also necessary, always,"³³ emphasizing the critical need for immediate engagement with social and political issues. This sense of urgency is contrasted with the paralyzing effects of fear that many face; as Lorde describes, individuals often sit in "fear of contempt, of censure, or some judgment, or recognition, of challenge, of annihilation."³⁴ Fear is a barrier to free expression, forcing societal change into a stalemate. However, Lorde offers a directive that highlights an avenue forward: "there are so many silences to be broken."³⁵ She acknowledges the challenges posed by fear but also serves as a rally cry for minority populations to overcome these obstacles and speak out through governmental participation. Her words push for courage and action.

Ultimately, Lorde's vision of individual freedom and relational equality encourages the reimagination of existing social structures and interpersonal dynamics in a way that honors and leverages individual differences for the collective good. By challenging the binary oppositions and reductionist thinking ingrained in current systems, her framework offers a foundation for a more just society. Traditional Western philosophies are a basis for understanding the social and political constructs, but overlook minority views. They encourage one standard way of thinking, instead of celebrating differences and finding commonality in shared struggles. An ethos that emphasizes differences and individuality must search for commonality as well as interdependency in order to achieve societal progress.

³³ Id.

³⁴ Lorde, "The Transformation of Silence into Language and Action" (1978), in *Sister Outsider*, 11.

³⁵ Lorde, "The Transformation of Silence into Language and Action," pp. 14.

The implementation of Lorde's theories into systems of governance requires a shift toward policy and that acknowledges and incorporates the varied perspectives and experiences of all community members, especially those excluded by existing oppressive systems. The politics of difference can be attained through inclusive policy-making, where diverse voices are heard in the decision-making process, and through laws that are designed to adapt to the needs of all. Lorde's vision inspires a world where the politics of difference drives collective efforts towards a future where freedom and equality reflect the true spectrum of human experience.

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